

Dancers Jaipur

The World at Their Feet

DREAM

To make Bollywood actors groove to their moves

Many had predicted her early exit from Zee TV's popular reality show *Dance India Dance* last year because of her weight. But defying all odds, 18-year-old Nonnie Sachdeva, a Class XII student of Maharani Gayatri Devi School in Jaipur, made it to the top 10. More than luck and SMS votes, it was her passion for dancing that got her there. But Sachdeva is not the only owner of happy feet produced by 37-year-old Brijesh Saxena's dance academy, Buskers. Set up in 1995 with just 23 students, today Buskers trains 2,500 students a year in six branches spread across the Pink City. Last year, Niharika Soni, 22, from the academy was selected for the Central India team in Sony's *Dance Premier League*, which stood second. Started in a small, nondescript room, today

the academy has a swimming pool, a gym, skating floor, coaching for taekwondo, riding and guitar lessons. A basic dance course for three months, five days a week and an hour a day costs Rs 2,600.

Like the pony-tailed Saxena, who had to defy his parents to make dancing his career, Soni, too, had a tough time convincing her family. A graduate in business management, her parents were initially reluctant to send her to Buskers and even resisted her going to the show, but seeing her on television was a moment of joy for them. "At a wedding, all our relatives were glued to the television to watch her dance just like villagers watch a cricket match," says Parvati, her now proud mother. Soni began learning dance four years ago and soon became the head in-

structor at Buskers. Though her parents still insist that she must prepare for the MBA exam and keep dancing as a part-time option, Soni wants to make it her career. "There is nothing like adopting a hobby as your profession."

It's the same for Sachdeva, who joined Buskers at the age of three. Now an instructor there, she says, "Dancing is my passion and I'll establish myself as a choreographer." She calls the academy her first home, spending up to six hours a day there sweating it out. It's all for a dream that appears to be universal. Ask Honey Mathur, 19, and his sister Umang, 21. Both want to make it to Bollywood and even have the support of their parents. It's the perfect union of passion and profession.

by Rohit Parihar

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR/www.indiatodayimages.com

"Dancing is a far more flexible career than a 10-to-8 marketing job."

NIHARIKA SONI Instructor, Buskers

(CENTRE) NONNIE SACHDEVA
AND NIHARIKA SONI; UMANG
(ON THEIR RIGHT)

